The Biography of a Word: *Run*

Introduction

The English word *run* is small, old and extremely busy. In the revised *Oxford English Dictionary* (OED), the verb alone has 645 senses, the most of any English word (NPR, 2011). This essay traces the word's origin, maps how its meanings relate to each other, describes some of its multi-word units, and compares how dictionaries handle its polysemy, that is, the fact that one word has several related meanings. The semantic analysis relies mainly on Gries (2006), who studied all 815 occurrences of *to run* in two corpora. A corpus is a large, searchable collection of real texts, and each single occurrence of the word in it is called a token. Gries's two corpora are the British component of the International Corpus of English (ICE-GB, 391 tokens) and the Brown Corpus of American English (424 tokens; Gries, 2006, p. 63).

Origin

Modern *run* merges two related Old English verbs. The first is the intransitive *rinnan/irnan*, "to run, flow, run together", which has cognates in Gothic *rinnan* and German *rinnen* "to flow" (Harper, n.d.-a). Cognates are related words in different languages that descend from a common ancestor. The second verb is the transitive *ærnan/earnan*, "ride, run to, reach", probably from Proto-Germanic **rannjanan*, the causative of a root meaning "to run" (Harper, n.d.-b). A causative is a verb meaning "to make something do the action", so this verb meant roughly "to make run". Harper (n.d.-c) notes that a link to a Proto-Indo-European root **rei-* "to run, flow" has been proposed but is doubtful, and that one source lists the word as having no certain Indo-European etymology. According to etymological dictionaries, the diachronically primary senses, meaning the earliest ones in history, are "fast pedestrian motion" and "to flow" (Partridge, 1961, as cited in Gries, 2006, p. 76).

Meanings and Their Relations

Gries (2006) compared 56 senses and arranged them in a radial network (Figure 1 in his paper), a diagram in which a central meaning is linked to the meanings that grew out of it. Intransitive uses, which take no direct object, make up about 65% of all tokens (p. 68). Two ways of identifying the central sense, called the prototype, point in different directions. The prototype is the most typical, best example of a word's meaning. A cognitive analysis that asks which sense most others can be derived from favours general "motion" (pp. 75–76). Corpus evidence instead favours "fast pedestrian motion", for four reasons (pp. 75–76):

1. It is the most frequent sense, at about 25% of tokens (203 of 815).
2. It is the most frequent sense in early child language data, in an analysis that Gries describes as still informal.
3. It is historically the first sense of the zero-derived noun, the noun *run* formed from the verb without any change of form.
4. It occurs in the widest range of formal and semantic contexts, which marks it as unmarked, that is, as the neutral default form of the word.

From this centre, meanings extend in several directions:

- **Non-pedestrian motion.** Gries's example is "three boats that run from the mainland to the Island" (2006, p. 64). The motion no longer needs to be fast or on foot.
- **Escape.** *Run away/off* is one of the most frequent extensions. Gries (2006, pp. 79–81) shows statistically that "escape" behaves more like the prototype than like general "motion", so it attaches directly to the prototype.
- **Flow and spreading.** Tears run, colours run, and a supply "runs out" (pp. 65–66).
- **Space and time.** Tracks "run" along a course, and this is extended to events lasting a period (*the play ran until one*) through the metaphor TIME IS SPACE (p. 67). *To extend spatially* has 55 tokens.
- **Abstract motion.** *Run for office*, *run into trouble* and *run through the bills* map goals and states onto destinations and locations, through the metaphors GOALS ARE DESTINATIONS and STATES ARE LOCATIONS (pp. 66–67). A fourth metaphor, MORE IS UP, explains *run up a bill*, where growing amounts are pictured as climbing (p. 70).
- **Causation and control.** *To cause motion* (*ran a finger down his cheek*) and related senses lead to transitive senses, which take a direct object. The most frequent of these are causative extensions of *to function*: *to manage* (101 tokens, 12.4% of all tokens) and *to execute/operate* (25 tokens; pp. 70–71, 85). Notably the second most frequent sense of *run* is an abstract one with no legs involved. *To function*, as in *the machine runs*, has 47 tokens.

Gries (2006, pp. 81–83) also grouped the senses by their grammatical and semantic behaviour using hierarchical cluster analysis, a statistical method that joins the most similar items step by step. The first split is between intransitive and transitive uses, and "fast pedestrian motion" and "escape" are joined earliest.

Multi-Word Units

Many meanings of *run* are carried by multi-word units rather than by the verb alone. Gries (2006, pp. 72–73) treats several as idioms, which are fixed expressions whose meaning cannot simply be added up from their parts. They include *run the risk* (12 tokens), *run the gamut*, *run the gauntlet* and *run roughshod over*. He observes that many of them alliterate, that is, repeat the same opening sound (p. 91, n. 11). Phrasal verbs, which combine a verb with a small word such as *out* or *across*, are also very numerous. The *Oxford Advanced American Dictionary* (Oxford Learner's Dictionaries, n.d.) lists a long set of *run* phrasal verbs, including *run across*, *run after*, *run away*, *run into*, *run off*, *run out*, *run over*, *run through* and *run up*. Their meanings are often figurative:

- *Run across* means "to meet with or discover by chance" (Merriam-Webster, n.d.).
- *Run out* means "to come to an end" or "to become used up" (Encyclopedia Britannica, n.d.).
- *Run over* means "to flow over the top or edge of something", which is overflow (Encyclopedia Britannica, n.d.).
- *Run through* covers using something up quickly, reading or practising it quickly, and occurring repeatedly throughout something (Encyclopedia Britannica, n.d.).

Fixed phrases built on the noun, such as *in the long run*, show the same pattern (Gries, 2006, p. 76).

Comparing Dictionaries

Dictionaries differ sharply in how finely they divide this word. The OED's revised entry reaches 645 verb senses and runs to roughly 75 columns of print (NPR, 2011). The *Oxford Advanced American Dictionary* is a learner's dictionary, written for people studying English as a foreign language. It lists a more compact set of senses, but still includes specific ones, for example "to bring or take something into a country illegally", as in *run guns* (Oxford Learner's Dictionaries, n.d.). The *Britannica Dictionary* has a learner-oriented entry that puts many meanings under phrasal-verb headings (Encyclopedia Britannica, n.d.), while Merriam-Webster (n.d.) gives *run across* an entry of its own. In short, the same meaning may be a sub-sense in one dictionary and a separate entry in another.

Gries (2006, p. 61) argues that this reflects subjective decisions about lumping, which means treating two uses as one sense, and splitting, which means treating them as two. He also found that some corpus senses, such as "to stop talking" and "to fail to understand", were missing from corpus-based dictionaries and unfamiliar to some native speakers (p. 87). He concludes that a linguist's intuition about which senses exist and how frequent they are is not a reliable data base on its own. A corpus-based profile is a useful complement to dictionaries, not a replacement for them.

The Interactive Mindmap

An interactive mindmap has been developed to accompany this study (Munkácsy, 2026). It presents the senses of *run* as a radial network based on Gries's (2006) analysis and modelled on his Figure 1 (p. 74). The mindmap extends his analysis in three respects. First, its nodes display the corpus frequencies reported by Gries and also include entries for the noun, adjective and adverb (for example *a run of bad luck*, *run-down* and *on the run*), whereas Gries's network covers only the verb. Second, the groupings by word class, by type of use (literal, metaphorical or metonymic, where metonymy refers to the use of one thing to stand for something related to it, as in *run for office* standing for an entire election campaign) and by detailed form (such as phrasal verb or countable noun) represent the author's own classification and do not derive from Gries. Third, example sentences are drawn from Gries only where they are marked as corpus examples; all others are constructed for illustration.

Limitations

The frequencies used here come from one small corpus. Gries himself notes that 815 tokens are not enough for a thorough multifactorial analysis (p. 87), that not every sense listed in reference works appeared in his data, and that his clustering results are preliminary (p. 81, 83).

Conclusion

The history of *run* leads from an Old English verb meaning both "to flow" and "to run", through a prototype of fast movement on foot, to hundreds of figurative and technical uses. Corpus data support a network centred on the prototype, with branches for escape, flow, extent, control and fixed expressions. Dictionaries record this network at very different levels of detail, which is why a word like *run* is best studied with several sources side by side.

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